Renderings of "what is design?"

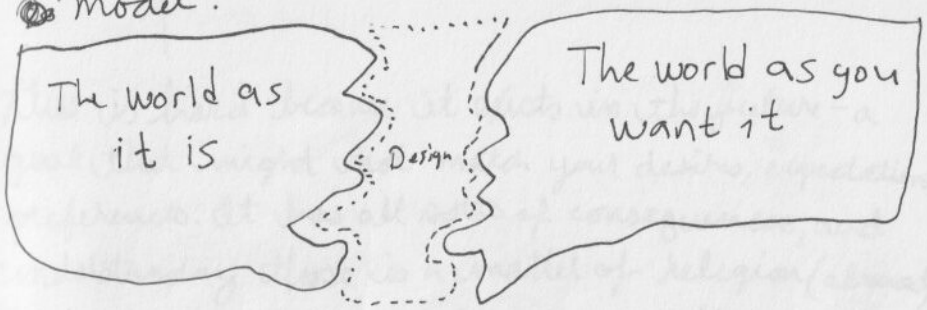
Design & "How to get a design job"

11/7/26

1-hour with questions/convo for CF1

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What is design? So much talk & posturing but such lack of consensus! My working model:



I've often drawn this as a map, rather than as present-and-future bridged by design:



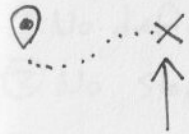
In both renderings, there are three parts -

- the starting condition (real)
- the desired ending condition (imagined)
- the approach for getting there (design)

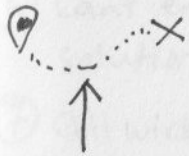
All of these are hard - even the starting point, because subjective reality depends on your point of view, so agreeing on what is real is a challenge!



this is hard because of personal perspective, which objective facts you have vs someone else, and are they even true? do other people value them in the same way? (no!)

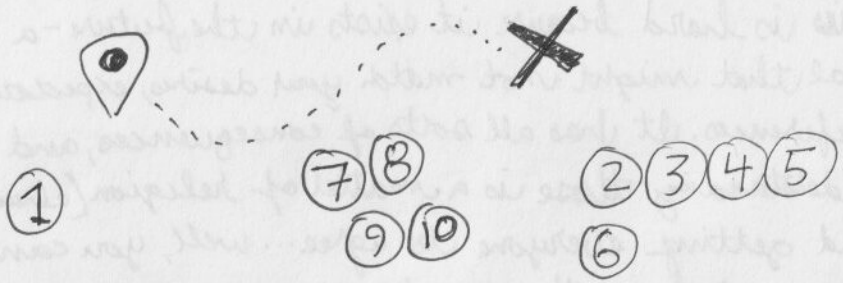


this is hard because it exists in the future - a goal that might not match your desires, expectations, preferences. it has all sorts of consequences, and understanding those is a matter of religion (almost). and getting everyone to agree... well, you can always reduce the number of people you ask.



this is crazy hard because it plots a path from an iffishly-defined starting point to a vaguely and aspirationally defined ending point through uncharted territory full of danger & intrigue, which all unfolds over time.

all three parts comprise design. ←←



This is a good time to mention wicked problems. Could do a whole talk on this, but briefly, we can list out the characteristics of wicked problems, as all design problems share at least some of these characteristics & sometimes all of them.★

① No definitive formulation	(problem set undefined)
② No stopping rule	(never done)
③ Not right or wrong, just better or worse	(non-binary ~~always striving~~)
④ No immediate/ultimate test of a solution	(no definitive test ~~always striving~~)
⑤ All solutions are one-shot; no opportunity to trial&error	(no trial & error)
⑥ Can't enumerate all possible solutions or operations	(solution set undefined)
⑦ All wicked problems unique	(one of a kind)
⑧ & they are all symptoms of other wicked problems	(symptoms)
⑨ Problem framing implies the nature of a solution	(framing begets solution)
⑩ Planner has no right to be wrong	(catch-22 consequences)

★ Not all design problems are wicked!
tame ——— wicked spectrum

wicked problem
as a framework for
understanding the
nature of design work

practical
headaches
management
colleagues
stakeholders

Bringing up wicked problems is useful because it gives us a vocabulary & framework for thinking about the breadth of challenges we face when doing design. And the simple three part diagrams helps structure it.

When designing you will have other stakeholders who do not really understand the vast problem that practitioners face — and so if (say) your boss doesn't get that the starting condition is unclear, or the intended solution is undesired by social groups they didn't consider, etc etc; then you not only have the already challenging job of designing, but also the added stress of an authority figure demanding results, unreasonably. ((Insult to injury))

There are many reasons why a design problem can go sideways, and ~~most of~~ many of them ~~are~~ are social — not because of anything as convenient as "other people are dumb" — but because we hold different knowledge, different understanding, different interests, different values, different motivations. ~~Sartre said "Hell is other people"~~

more "how to do the job" – tactics for social cohesion while getting the job done.

The job of designing is largely around navigating these social situations – clients, colleagues, management, all the while there are technical and economic unknowns and constraints. It is deeply rewarding when it works, when you ship something (or build or enact, or whatever verb you want) and land it.

But getting there is 99% of the job, and it can be fraught. And in navigating the social situation, your own thoughts & actions can fight against you –

QUALITY VS. QUANTITY isn't really apt –

~~Fast~~ getting the right design ⇒
getting the design right

perfectionism can fight you if your framing is imperfect (and it is!)

You have to know when to relent, and not engage in "pixel fucking" as a boss I once had put it.

You also need to know when to go wide – get ideas, frame the problem, – and when to go deep – focus on a solution and detail it – and when to get feedback (objective and subjective are both good) – and there is an art to taking feedback & incorporating it usefully.

more on doing the job

If you can articulate and defend an argument around the parts



1. Current reality
2. Desired reality
3. Path for getting there

... and get agreement & buy in with the stakeholders, you're doing great.

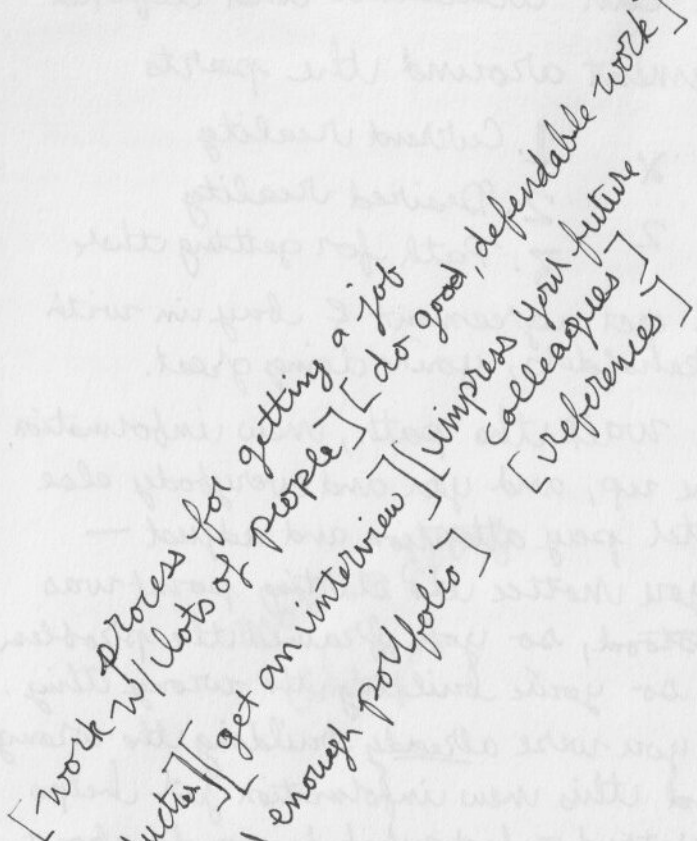
As you walk the path, new information will come up, and you and everybody else had better pay attention and adjust — maybe you notice the starting point was misunderstood, so you framed the problem wrong, so you're building the wrong thing.

Well... you were already building the wrong thing, and this new information just helps you understand — but what do you do about it? Tweak the design & keep going? Light it on fire & go back to the drawing board? Have shouting matches with your colleagues over who was wrong? Or, languish in meetings while avoiding the conversation?

Pretty sure is a Dr. Seuss book on just this topic...

~

Suffice it to say, design is a lot of social work, & not just pushing pixels all day.



So if you still want to work as a designer, this is what you should be good at: understanding the current reality, framing the problem, understanding people (everyone, not just the users!), planning the solution, and being prepared for bumps on the path. And yes, you will push pixels - but the job is mostly people.

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To get a job as a designer, the best way is to know somebody who is hiring - or know somebody who knows somebody. And I don't mean your LinkedIn network (though that is important too...) - I mean people who would go to bat for you.

And that means (a) working with a lot of different people, and (b) having done good work so they will remember & go to bat!

Carpet bombing your resume is a waste of time. Everybody does it, and hiring managers get overwhelmed so they get lazy - "who do I know?" and ask on socials. (this is where LI helps.)

So when your former classmate / colleague sees this, they think of you - why would they think of ~~you~~ you? — and you get an intro. Either say yes or no - have follow-through. If you ghost them, whoever did the intro also looks bad - this has been one — so you can do damage to yourself by flaking out.

Hiring managers want to know who you are, and what you can do and what your history has been, and what you'd add to the team. Your resume and portfolio will help them quickly get to a "No" or "maybe" - because even a 15 minute screening call is a hassle.

* important - resume / portfolio is your ABBB. It must be good to get you an interview, your interviewers will likely look closer, but this is still superficial.